This time, Anglo-Russian rivalry would lead to 800,000 deaths.

At the end of *Kim*, Kipling has his eponymous hero say, ‘When everyone is dead, the Great Game is finished. Not before.’

In the 1980s it was the Russians’ withdrawal from their failed occupation of Afghanistan that triggered the beginning of the end of the Soviet Union. Less than twenty years later, in 2001, British and American troops arrived in Afghanistan where they proceeded to begin losing what was, in Britain’s case, its fourth war in that country. As before, in the end, despite all the billions of dollars handed out, the training of an entire army of Afghan troops and the infinitely superior weaponry of the occupiers, the Afghan resistance succeeded again in first surrounding then propelling the hated Kafirs into a humiliating exit. In both cases the occupying troops lost the will to continue fighting at such cost and with so little gain.

For all the differences, there are of course striking parallels between the twenty-first-century occupation of Afghanistan and that of 1839–42. There is a real continuity in the impact of political geography on the evolution of both conflicts. The significance of Kabul’s location is one issue – adjacent to both the Tajik population of Kohistan, on one side, and the eastern Ghilzais on the other. Then there is the tribal issue, as another Popalzai ruler lacking a real power base, Hamid Karzai – astonishingly, from the same sub-tribe as Shah Shuja – faces the brunt of concerted guerrilla attacks led by the eastern Ghilzai who today make up the footsoldiers of the Taliban. They are directed by another Ghilzai tribal leader from the Hotak ruling clan, in this case Mullah Omar.[pp153]

On my extended visits to Afghanistan to research this book in 2009 and 2010, I set myself two goals. Firstly I wanted to try to find the elusive Afghan sourcestelling of the war which I was certain had to exist and which I have in due course used to write this book. Secondly, I was keen to see as many of the places and landscapes associated with the First Afghan War as was possible in a situation where ISAF’s[qq] hold on Afghanistan was already visibly shrinking every day. By 2010, the Taliban had a strong presence in over 70 per cent of the country and Karzai’s government had firm control of only twenty-nine out of 121 key strategic districts. That 70 per cent included most of the route of the British retreat of January 1842 which I knew I would have to travel if I was to have an idea of the geography I was